



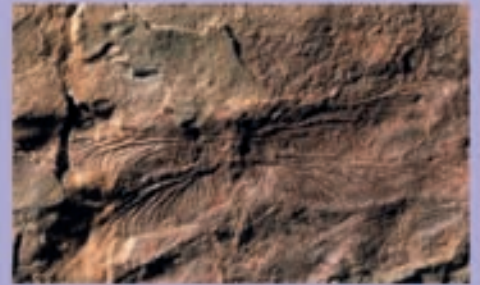
Meganeura

MEGA-new-ra



- **When** 300 million years ago (Late Carboniferous)
- **Fossil location** Europe
- **Habitat** Tropical swamp forests
- **Wingspan** Up to 30 in (75 cm)

Meganeura was not a true dragonfly but a member of a closely related family called griffinflies. It had stronger legs than modern dragonflies and a simpler pattern of veins in its wings. It flew quickly through tropical forests, using its huge compound eyes to spot prey. It could snatch flying insects in midair, grabbing them with its legs and bringing them up to its mouth to devour as it flew.



▲ VEINS IN WINGS

Meganeura means “large-veined.” This fossil, found in France, shows the thick veins that acted as struts to stiffen the large, delicate wings.



▲ WINGED WONDER

Like modern dragonflies, *Meganeura* flapped its front and rear wings separately and perhaps at different speeds, giving it a fine control of flight. Dragonflies are amazingly agile, able to hover, fly backward, and change direction in an instant.

LIVING RELATIVE

One of the world's largest dragonflies today is the giant dragonfly (*Petalura gigantea*), which is found in New South Wales, Australia. Despite having a wingspan of almost 5½ in (14 cm), it is actually quite a poor flyer, and rarely moves far from its area. Like its ancestors, it eats flying insects.

